

ESL 130: LOW INTERMEDIATE ESL WRITING



Heather Zettelmaier
Washtenaw Community College

Low Intermediate ESL Writing

Heather Zettelmaier

Washtenaw Community College

This text is disseminated via the Open Education Resource (OER) LibreTexts Project (<https://LibreTexts.org>) and like the thousands of other texts available within this powerful platform, it is freely available for reading, printing, and "consuming."

The LibreTexts mission is to bring together students, faculty, and scholars in a collaborative effort to provide an accessible, and comprehensive platform that empowers our community to develop, curate, adapt, and adopt openly licensed resources and technologies; through these efforts we can reduce the financial burden born from traditional educational resource costs, ensuring education is more accessible for students and communities worldwide.

Most, but not all, pages in the library have licenses that may allow individuals to make changes, save, and print this book. Carefully consult the applicable license(s) before pursuing such effects. Instructors can adopt existing LibreTexts texts or Remix them to quickly build course-specific resources to meet the needs of their students. Unlike traditional textbooks, LibreTexts' web based origins allow powerful integration of advanced features and new technologies to support learning.



LibreTexts is the adaptable, user-friendly non-profit open education resource platform that educators trust for creating, customizing, and sharing accessible, interactive textbooks, adaptive homework, and ancillary materials. We collaborate with individuals and organizations to champion open education initiatives, support institutional publishing programs, drive curriculum development projects, and more.

The LibreTexts libraries are Powered by [NICE CXone Expert](#) and was supported by the Department of Education Open Textbook Pilot Project, the California Education Learning Lab, the UC Davis Office of the Provost, the UC Davis Library, the California State University Affordable Learning Solutions Program, and Merlot. This material is based upon work supported by the National Science Foundation under Grant No. 1246120, 1525057, and 1413739.

Any opinions, findings, and conclusions or recommendations expressed in this material are those of the author(s) and do not necessarily reflect the views of the National Science Foundation nor the US Department of Education.

Have questions or comments? For information about adoptions or adaptations contact info@LibreTexts.org or visit our main website at <https://LibreTexts.org>.

This text was compiled on 04/18/2026

TABLE OF CONTENTS

[Licensing](#)

1: Chapters

- [1: Sentences](#)
- [2: Summary Writing](#)
- [3: The Basics of Paragraphs](#)
- [4: Routines and Opinions- Using the Simple Present](#)
- [5: Narrative Writing- Using the Simple Past](#)
- [6: Supporting Opinions with Reasons](#)

2: Appendix

- [2.1: Appendix A- List of Frequently Misspelled Words](#)
- [2.2: Appendix B- Personal Spelling List and Practice](#)
- [2.3: Appendix C- Gerund Subjects and Non-referential \("dummy"\) It](#)
- [2.4: Appendix D- Plural Agreement and Basic Article Use](#)

[Index](#)

[Glossary](#)

[Peer Reviews](#)

[Detailed Licensing](#)

Licensing

A detailed breakdown of this resource's licensing can be found in [Back Matter/Detailed Licensing](#).

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

1: Chapters

- 1: Sentences
- 2: Summary Writing
- 3: The Basics of Paragraphs
- 4: Routines and Opinions- Using the Simple Present
- 5: Narrative Writing- Using the Simple Past
- 6: Supporting Opinions with Reasons

1: Chapters is shared under a [not declared](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

✓ Practice 1A

Put the following words from the list (1-250) into categories. Write them in the chart. HINT: Some of the words can be in more than one group!

between	make	thing	give
point	include	end	important
read	government	study	around

NOUNS	VERBS	ADJECTIVES	PREPOSITIONS

✓ Practice 1B

Choose either the noun or verb form of the words on the left to write in the sentences on the right. Put the word in the correct grammatical form.

Noun	Verb	Sentence practice
work	work	1. My brother _____ for Ford Motor Company. 2. I enjoy cooking for people, but it's a lot of _____.
study studies	study	3. I quit my job so I could focus on my _____. 4. Jaime _____ at the library on Sunday afternoons. 5. A _____ showed that most people in Ann Arbor drive cars to work.
requirement	require	6. Intermediate ESL Grammar is a _____ for me. 7. This class _____ 800 pages of reading.
experience	experience	8. When I came to the U.S., I _____ stress because of culture shock. 9. Traveling around the world has given Karla many interesting _____. 10. I volunteer at the hospital just to get _____.

Good **sentences** are essential for good writing. A sentence is a group of words that expresses a complete thought. To be a *complete sentence*, we need to:

- begin with a capital letter.
- end with a period. The other possible punctuation marks are a question mark (?) and exclamation point (!). These are not used often. Use a period at the end of most sentences.
- include a subject and verb.
- *be careful to write a complete thought*

Example:

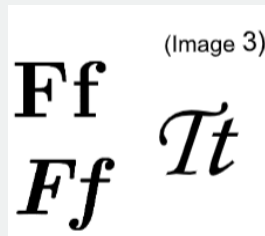
RIGHT: I was absent because I was sick. (complete sentence)

WRONG: Because I was sick. (NOT a sentence: *because* should connect to other parts of the sentence)



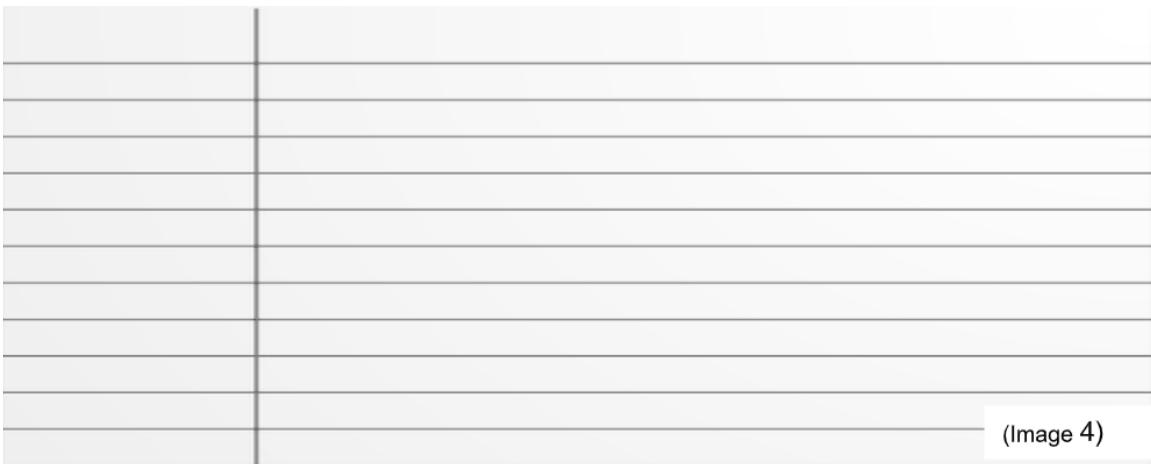
Note

When writing by hand, be careful to make clear capital letters. Sometimes handwriting can be confusing! Look at these *f* and *t* letters.



Write: For example, I like French fries.

Write: There are three people in the car.



Here are some more rules about capital letters in English:

1. Use a capital letter with *proper nouns*. These are usually the names of specific people, places or things. Most English nouns are *common nouns* and do not get capital letters. Here are some examples of proper nouns:

names of streets, cities, states, countries, and people, including their titles:

<u>D</u> etroit <u>I</u> stanbul	<u>T</u> hailand <u>M</u> exico	the <u>U</u> nited <u>S</u> tates <u>L</u> akeview <u>C</u> ourt	<u>M</u> ain <u>S</u> treet <u>N</u> evada
<u>G</u> eorge <u>W</u> ashington <u>M</u> s. <u>B</u> rown		<u>D</u> r. Matthew Green <u>U</u> ncle <u>W</u> ally	

names of geographic places, companies, institutions, and buildings

the <u>S</u> tate <u>T</u> heatre the <u>N</u> ile <u>R</u> iver	<u>S</u> mith <u>W</u> indow <u>C</u> ompany <u>L</u> incoln <u>E</u> lementary <u>S</u> chool
---	---

2. The pronoun *I* is always capitalized in English.

Quang and I have known each other for five years.

3. There are specific rules for capital letters in titles.

War and Pease is an epic novel by Leo Tolstoy.

We enjoyed watching the movie Beauty and the Beast.

✓ Practice 1C

In the following paragraph, try to fix the errors in:

- capital letters
- end of sentence punctuation

My family and i took a wonderful trip to chicago this summer we took the train from ann arbor we went to shedd aquarium and millennium park. we stayed at a nice hotel and ate at many wonderful restaurants, on the last day we went swimming in lake michigan the weather was perfect we all relaxed and slept on the train back to michigan.

What does a **paragraph** look like? More instruction on formal paragraph writing will come in Unit 3, The Basics of Paragraphs. For now, start writing with the correct **paragraph format**. Here are some basic requirements:

1. **Write your name, class (ESL 128), and the date in the upper left corner.**
2. **Indent.** If you are writing by hand, put about a two-finger space in front of the first sentence. If you are typing, use the TAB key for the first line.
3. **Do not start each new sentence on a new line.**

Example:

✗ Wrong

Saturday is my favorite day of the week.

I work Monday through Friday, so on Saturday, I sleep in.

Then my family and I eat a big breakfast and stay in our pajamas for hours. After that, we often go to a movie or visit some friends.

I cook dinner every day except Saturdays.

We usually go out to a restaurant or order pizza for dinner on Saturday. Every week, I look forward to Saturday.

📌 Right

Saturday is my favorite day of the week. I work Monday through Friday, so on Saturday, I sleep in. Then my family and I eat a big breakfast and stay in our pajamas for hours. After that, we often go to a movie or visit some friends. I cook dinner every day except Saturdays. We usually go out to a restaurant or order pizza for dinner on Saturday. Every week, I look forward to Saturday.

4. **Double-space.** Skip one line between each line.
5. **If you are typing, use a 12-point font.**
6. If your paragraph has a **title**, **center** it.

Here is an example of a typed paragraph, correctly formatted.

Nadya Jackson
ESL 128
September 12, 2017

My Family

There are four people in my family. My husband's name is Jake. We have been married since 2006. Jake is an exterminator and an artist. We have two boys, an eight-year-old named Henry and a six-year-old named Louis. Henry loves to play video games and read scary stories. Louis likes to draw and wrestle. Both of my boys play the piano. We are a busy family, but we love to spend time together.

✓ Practice 1D

What is wrong with the FORMAT of these paragraphs?

1. Nadya

There are four people in my family. My husband's name is Jake. We have been married since 2006. Jake is an exterminator and an artist. We have two boys, an eight-year-old named Henry and a six-year-old named Louis. Henry loves to play video games and read scary stories. Louis likes to draw and wrestle. Both of my boys play the piano. We are a busy family, but we love to spend time together.

MISTAKE #1: _____

MISTAKE #2: _____

MISTAKE #3: _____

2. Nadya Jackson

ELS 128

Introduce My Family

9/12/17

There are four people in my family.

My husband's name is Jake. We have been married since 2006. Jake is an exterminator and an artist.

We have two boys, an eight-year-old named Henry and a six-year-old named Louis. Henry loves to play video games and read scary stories. Louis likes to draw and wrestle. Both of my boys play the piano.

We are a busy family, but we love to spend time together.

MISTAKE #1: _____

MISTAKE #2: _____

MISTAKE #3: _____

Every sentence in English must have a **Subject** and a **Verb**, and most sentences have an **Object**. Before we are able to write longer sentences, we should make sure that our simple sentences are correct. Simple sentences have the basic parts of a sentence: Subject, Verb and Object = S V O

How do we find the Subject? → ask WHO?

How do we find the Verb and Object? → ask DID WHAT?

S V O

My daughter is attending preschool at WCC this semester.

Look at the examples below.

S V O

Amjed is a student.

S V O

Megan loves reading.

✓ Practice 1E

Label the sentences below with S V O.



(Image 5)

1. Painting is my favorite hobby.
2. The Johnson family loves camping.
3. Ali can run twelve miles.
4. Maria and David are getting a new car.
5. Do you like your present ?
6. Who is your favorite movie star?
7. What is your favorite subject?
8. Leo has seven dogs and six cats.
9. ESL 128 is a fun class.
10. Washtenaw Community College has over 10,000 students.

✓ Practice 1F

On a separate piece of paper, write a short paragraph about yourself. Your paragraph should have five *simple* sentences. Label your sentences S V O. Use *correct paragraph format*.

✓ Practice 1G

In the sentences below, cross out all other parts of the sentence that are not the S V O. Label the S V O.

S V O

Example: Peter drove his car ~~to the market~~.

1. Megan is studying at the library.
2. In the afternoon, the baby takes a nap.



(Image 6)

3. We usually check our homework at the beginning of class.
4. My daughters are cleaning their rooms.
5. Tom drove to the college quickly.
6. Jem was born in Kijabe in 1999.
7. Ken gave the card to Barb.
8. Chop six carrots and put them in the pot.
9. Amy bought a new car from Craig's List.

Many sentences add information about where and when the activity happened. Thus, to understand sentences with S V O, we can add **P** and **T**. *P* refers to the *place* of the action. *T* refers to the *time* of the action. Place comes *before* Time in sentences and *after* the S V O. Place and Time are given in adverbs, expressions, and prepositional phrases.

How do we find the Subject? → ask WHO?

How do we find the Verb and Object? → ask DID WHAT?

How do we find the Place? → ask WHERE?

How do we find the Time? → ask WHEN?

S V O P T

My daughter is attending preschool at WCC this semester.

Note

Time (T) may come *before* the S V O but is separated with a comma (,).

T S V O P

This semester, my daughter is attending preschool at WCC.

✓ Practice 1H

Label the sentences below with S V O P T.

1. Jacques and Lou play soccer at the park every Saturday.
2. Before breakfast, Martha must do her chores.
3. My family is going to see the new Captain America movie at the Rave Theater tonight.
4. The grammar students took a diagnostic test in class yesterday.
5. At 6 pm tomorrow, I am meeting my cousin at the new Italian restaurant downtown.

✓ Practice 1I

On a separate piece of paper, write a short paragraph about a place you like to visit when you have a day off. Your paragraph should have six *simple* sentences. Label your sentences S V O, and P T as necessary. Use *correct paragraph format*.

✓ Practice 1J

For more practice, label the following sentences with S V O P T.



1. Hassan saw a picture on the wall.
2. Hassan looked at the picture.
3. Hassan recognized the people in the picture.
4. Annika lost her ring yesterday.
5. Annika lost her ring in the sand.
6. Annika lost her ring in the sand at the beach.
7. We were at a meeting.
8. Please be on time in the future.
9. We bought a house in Miami in 2005.
10. Last night, we went to a movie.

✓ Practice 1K

Write sentences using the words given. Use S V O P T word order.

1. began / last week / Kimi / through Turkey / a bike trip

2. at his uncle's bakery / Alexi / on Saturday mornings / works

3. arrived / in the early morning / at the airport / my plane

4. are going to take / on Wednesday / the 128 students / an SVOPT quiz / in class

Each language of the world has its own grammatical rules for **word order**. How does your first language order sentences? Is it **S V O P T**?

Translate the sentence "We drink coffee in the garden every afternoon." Write it in your language. Then explain the word order to a partner.

Some languages require an "extra" subject or object that does not translate well into English. Other languages don't require a "be" verb. Some languages don't require an *It* subject before verbs. Translating these grammar rules can cause incomplete sentences, or sentences that have extra words in English.

✓ Practice 1L

The following sentences have errors in English word order and sentence structure. Rewrite the sentences correctly on the line.

1. My hobby is reading books, religious, cooking, and health books.

2. My husband understands me and tries to give me sometimes a chance to go to parties.

3. The cow gives every day five liters of milk.

4. My daughter, she is six years old.

5. Audrey Hepburn in this movie is a very lovely princess.

6. My brother, he works the night shift at the airport.

✓ Practice 1M

The following sentences have errors using *It* and the *be* verb. Rewrite the sentences correctly on the line.

1. This city is the capital of my country. It always busy with people and cars.

2. When I there, I enjoy all of the markets.

3. My birthday in July. Is often rainy when I celebrate my birthday in Mexico.

4. I could feel the earthquake and hear the dishes shaking. Was a day that I will never forget.

A common error in writing is **run-on sentences**. What is a run-on sentence?

A run-on sentence is two or more sentences put together with *not enough punctuation*. A *comma is not enough*. Two sentences separated by a comma is called a **comma splice**. This is a kind of run-on sentence.

Example: X We waited patiently our flight finally started boarding.

X We waited patiently, our flight finally started boarding.

There are several ways to correct run-on sentences:

- Separate the sentences with a period. → We waited patiently. Our flight finally started boarding.
- Add a connecting word to make the sentence correct.

→ We waited patiently until our flight finally started boarding.

→ We waiting patiently, and our flight finally started boarding.

✓ Practice 1N

Which sentences are correct? Which are incorrect? Mark the correct sentences with “C” and the incorrect with “I.”

1. _____ The gym is my social spot, I meet a lot of friends there.

2. _____ I always feel better after I work out and see my friends at the gym.

3. _____ You can watch the dolphins while you are waiting for your food.

4. _____ I started to learn English I felt very good.

5. _____ Bathrooms here are very different, they're harder to clean.

✓ Practice 1O

All of the following sentences are run-on sentences or comma splices. Correct the sentences. Rewrite them on the lines.

1. Farming is a good business, people always need to eat.

2. I learned guitar because I wanted to, I listened, watched people, and followed the video of a guy who plays the guitar very well.

3. There are long beaches in Rio, I can go swimming and fishing and play soccer and many more activities.

4. Facebook it is really the thing I can enjoy it, it is a good hobby for me. [extra Subject and Object]

Attributions

Image 1:

“25 things about my friends In a Word Cloud” by Aldon Hynes is licensed via Flickr under [CC BY-SA 2.0](#).

Image 2:

“Basic constituent structure analysis of a sentence (The cat sat on the mat)” by AnonMoos is licensed via Wikimedia Commons under [CC BY SA_3.0](#).

Image 3:

“Latin letter F” by Spider is licensed via Wikimedia Commons under [CC BY-SA_3.0](#).

Image 4:

“Document Page Text Paper Empty” is licensed via Pixabay under [CC0](#) 1.0.

Image 5:

“Pitching a tent at Bear Creek Lake State Park” by vastateparkstaff is licensed via Wikimedia Commons under [CC BY 2.0](#).

Image 6:

“Newborn sleeping” by Vera Kratochvil is licensed via Public Domain Files under [Public Domain Mark 1.0](#).

Image 7:

“Sandy Ring” by Derek Gavey is licensed via Flickr under [CC BY 2.0](#).

This page titled [1: Sentences](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Heather Zettelmaier](#) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

SECTION OVERVIEW

2: Summary Writing

Summary writing is a very important skill in American college classes. Teachers will ask you to write summaries of articles, textbook chapters, books, and even movies. In addition, you will also have to give summaries orally, to see whether or not you understood the text.

Remember these things when writing a summary:

- Include **ONLY** the main points. Do not include unnecessary details.
- Write **IN YOUR OWN WORDS**. Copying parts of the text shows that you have not understood the text, only that you can repeat it. It can also be considered *cheating*.
- Do not include your opinion. A summary is objective.
- Summaries are **SHORT**. You may summarize 5-6 pages of academic text in one paragraph.
- Summaries should be **ACCURATE** and **COMPLETE**. This is where careful reading is so important. Your summary should show that you fully understand the **ENTIRE** article. You may need to read an article or text several times and discuss it with someone before writing a summary.

Sample text:

A penny for your thoughts? If it's a 1943 copper penny, it could be worth as much as fifty thousand dollars. In 1943, most pennies were made out of steel since copper was needed for World War I, so the 1943 copper penny is ultra-rare. Another rarity is the 1955 double-die penny. These pennies were mistakenly double stamped, so they have overlapping dates and letters. If it's uncirculated, it would easily fetch \$25,000 at an auction. Now that's a pretty penny.

BAD summary #1:

This text is about pennies.

What's wrong with this summary?

- 1.
- 2.

BAD summary #2:

Copper was hard to get during World War II, so there aren't many pennies from that time. The 1955 double die penny is worth a lot too. These pennies were stamped twice by accident.

What's wrong with this summary?

- 1.
- 2.

BAD summary #3:

Some pennies are worth a lot of money. If it's a 1943 copper penny, it might be worth up to \$50,000. That's because in 1943, most pennies were made out of steel. Another rare penny is the 1955 double-die penny. It might get \$25,000 at an auction.

What's wrong with this summary?

- 1.
- 2.

GOOD summary:

This text is about two very rare and valuable pennies: the 1943 copper penny and the 1955 double die penny.

This summary:

- Includes main ideas.
- Doesn't include unnecessary information
- Is a complete sentence.

Note

Taking phrases or sentences from another writer without using “quotations marks” is called *plagiarism*. It is a serious offense in American colleges and schools. The WCC policy says that the student will get a “0” for an assignment or even an “F” for a class. Students who continue to do this can be disciplined by the Dean or other administrators. Moreover, a good summary doesn't use direct “quotes”; if you do, it looks like you didn't understand the reading.

Here are some tips for avoiding plagiarism while writing a summary:

- Imagine someone asked you “What was the text about?” or “What was the book about?”
- Read the text several times to make sure you understand it.
- It helps to take some notes about the reading on a separate piece of paper – not sentences, just a few words or phrases. Bullet points or lists work well.
- Do not look at the text while you are writing the summary.
- Give the summary to someone out loud (orally) before you write it down. This is an excellent way to pre-write and practice. They can also ask you questions for clarification.

✓ Practice 2A

Write a summary of a movie.

As a class, decide on a movie to summarize. Choose one that everyone in the class has seen, such as *Titanic*. Discuss the main ideas (events) of this movie with a partner or in a small group.

After you have discussed the ideas orally, write a brief summary of the movie on a separate piece of paper. Write the summary in 10 minutes or less. Be prepared to share your summary.

✓ Practice 2B

Write a summary of an article.

Your instructor will ask you to write a summary of a text from your reading textbook. Follow the guidelines above to write a brief summary that includes only main ideas. Your instructor will have further instructions about the required length of the summary. Write it on a separate piece of paper.

Exchange your summary with a partner. Your instructor will give you a Peer Editing Checklist for the summary.

Writing a summary of a book that you have read for pleasure is another important skill. For this course, you will write short summaries of many stories that you read. Fiction stories should be summarized using the *simple present tense*. The following is a sample summary of a short story called *My Cousin*. The format includes the book's title, author, and number of pages.

My Cousin author unknown 4 pages

This story is about a little girl who wants to meet her cousin. She knows her cousin's name is Pat, and she writes it all over the walls in her house. One day, the girl's mother takes her into the country, and she meets her cousin. The cousin is an older woman. The girl is surprised and pleased.

How many sentences are in this summary? Underline all of the *simple present verbs* in the summary.

✓ Practice 2C

Grammar is always important! Here is a summary of the same story, *My Cousin*. There are errors in sentence structure, punctuation, and verb tense. Identify and fix the grammar errors.

A girl she was five years old she saw a picture of another girl under a tree, her mother said it was her cousin, the girl wrote her name on all the walls, she wanted to meet her cousin. Because she was an only child.

Now look at the content. How are the contents of the two summaries different? Would you change the contents of the second summary? Why or why not? Discuss your ideas with a partner.

✓ Practice 2D

Bring one of the books that you've read at the library to class. Your classmates will ask you, "What is that book about?" You should summarize the book in 2 minutes to a partner.

Switch partners. Answer the question, "What is that book about?" in 1 minute.

Switch partners. Answer the question, "What is that book about?" in 30 seconds.

Could you summarize the book in 30 seconds?

Some tips for writing good book report summaries:

- Write the title, the author, and number of pages read at the top of the summary
- Keep your summary short, 2 to 5 sentences
- Write your summary in a paragraph format.
- Do NOT:
 - Write a list of sentences
 - Number your sentences
 - Write only phrases (fragments)
 - Write many run-on sentences, connected with commas. Fragments and run-ons make it difficult to see how many sentences you really wrote.

Students who copy the summary from the back of the book or from any part of any chapter are *plagiarizing* and will receive a "0" for the book report. Your instructor will keep a record of your plagiarism and possibly send you to the Dean for discipline.

Remember, *plagiarism* can mean copying even parts of sentences and inserting synonyms here and there.

Put the book away when you are writing about it! Write from your own memory.



(Image 1)

Attributions

“Summarizing: Getting to the Point” by Ereading Worksheets is licensed under Terms of Use.

Image 1:

“Blank stop sign octagon” by MgcImage via [Wikimedia Commons](#) is in the [Public Domain](#).

This page titled [2: Summary Writing](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Heather Zettelmaier](#) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

SECTION OVERVIEW

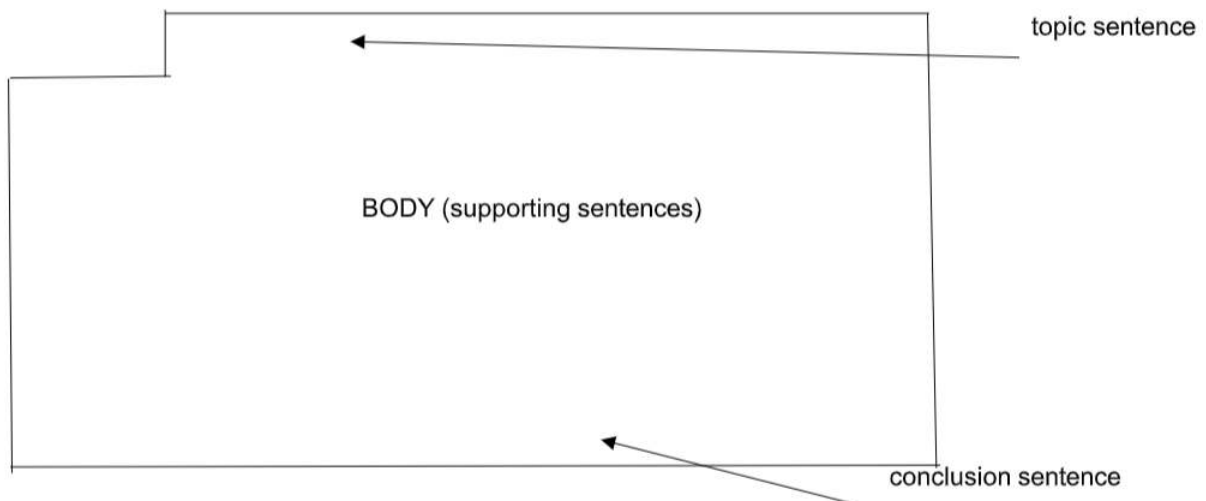
3: The Basics of Paragraphs

In academic writing, a **paragraph** is a group of sentences about a single topic. Paragraphs can be different lengths in different writing situations. For low intermediate writers, anywhere from 4 to 12 sentences is a good length for a paragraph. Your instructor will make sure you know how many sentences are expected for each writing assignment.

A good paragraph has three parts:

1. a **topic sentence** that states what you will write about
2. **supporting sentences** (the body) that add explanations and details about the topic
3. a **conclusion sentence** that wraps up the paragraph, similar to the topic sentence

Remember, a paragraph is indented. Each sentence comes right after the other one, not on a new line. Each sentence ends with a period. A paragraph's form looks something like this:



Read the following sample paragraph.

There are several reasons why I am studying at Washtenaw Community College. First, the tuition is very low. I can take college classes at WCC for less than half of the cost of a university class. Second, WCC has great teachers and student support. My teachers really care about their students. Class sizes are small, and lots of free tutoring is available. Finally, WCC is close to my house. I live only five miles from WCC, so I can ride the bus there in less than 20 minutes. I could even ride my bike there in nice weather. For all of these reasons, I am taking classes at WCC.

Underline the topic sentence.

What is this paragraph about?

How many reasons are given in the body of the paragraph? What are they? Write a word or phrase for each reason.

- 1.
- 2.
- 3.

Circle the conclusion sentence.

How many sentences are there in this paragraph?

The **topic sentence** is usually the first sentence of a paragraph, especially in student writing. A topic sentence should contain two things:

1. the main idea of the paragraph

- ~~the topic that you will write about~~
your opinion or personal feeling of the topic. This is often called a controlling idea.

Some topic sentences also make the plan of the paragraph clear. For example, the topic sentence might have a plan like, “for many reasons,” “several qualities,” “three things,” or “a few differences.”

A good topic sentence is not too general and not too specific. It shows the reader what will come in the paragraph. A good topic sentence does NOT:

- Announce the topic.

 Wrong

“I am going to write about WCC.”

- Ask a question.

 Wrong

“Why am I going to WCC? I’d like to tell you.”

- Stand above the paragraph. It is NOT a title. It is a complete sentence.

 Wrong

There are several reasons why I am studying at Washtenaw Community College.

First, the tuition is very low. I can take college classes at WCC for less than half of the cost of a university class. Second, WCC has great teachers and student support. My teachers really care about their students. Class sizes are small, and lots of free tutoring is available. Finally, WCC is close to my house. I live only five miles from WCC, so I can ride the bus there in less than 20 minutes. I could even ride my bike there in nice weather. For all of these reasons, I am taking classes at WCC.

- State a fact.

 Wrong

“WCC is located in Ann Arbor, Michigan.”

✓ Practice 3A

Read the following topic sentences about American cities. Do they contain both the topic and a controlling idea? Check the boxes.

This topic sentence contains a:

1. Washington, DC, is the capital of my country.	☐ topic	☐ controlling idea
2. New Orleans is a very interesting city.	☐ topic	☐ controlling idea
3. There are many people in Los Angeles.	☐ topic	☐ controlling idea
4. St. Augustine is a very beautiful city.	☐ topic	☐ controlling idea
5. New York is the biggest city in the U.S.	☐ topic	☐ controlling idea

✓ Practice 3B

Read the following paragraphs. Fill in the blanks with a good topic sentence. Work with a partner, alone, or in a small group.

Paragraph 1: Good Neighbors

_____. First, a good neighbor is quiet. Even if a neighbor is nice, it is hard to tolerate loud music late at night or dogs that bark a lot. Second, good neighbors are respectful. It is nice to have polite conversation with your neighbor. Neighbors should also respect others by shoveling their sidewalk in the winter and leaving enough parking space for everyone. Finally, a really good neighbor is generous. A good neighbor might bring you cookies during the holiday, or give you some gas if your lawn mower runs out. These are some of the most important qualities of a good neighbor.

Paragraph 2: Reducing Stress

_____. One way to reduce stress is to exercise. Some people jog or play high-impact sports to relax. Others just take a walk or a short bike ride. Another idea is talking to a friend or family member. It helps just to express how you are feeling when you are stressed. Lastly, listening to music can help you relax. Quiet, classical music relaxes some people. Listening to loud pop music while singing and dancing also releases stress. We all have stress, and these are three ways to reduce it.

Paragraph 3: My Worst Job

_____. I earned a lot of money from that job, but I was more miserable than I have ever been in my life. Working on an assembly line was very boring, and I had to concentrate the whole time with almost no breaks. All day long, I had to put DVDs into boxes, and I had to work very fast. The factory was hot and stuffy. Also, the supervisors watched us closely and yelled us when we weren't working fast enough. Maybe the worst part of the job was the mood of my coworkers. It seemed like they all complained and gossiped. I didn't make a single friend in the eight months that I worked there. In sum, working in a factory was truly one of the worst experiences that I have ever had.

Supporting sentences begin right after the topic sentence of the paragraph. A good writer will have two or three separate ideas that support the topic as it is stated in the topic sentence. Each supporting idea should be introduced clearly, usually with a *transition word* or phrase. These transitions are a big signal to the reader that a new idea is being introduced. Using these transition words keeps the body of the paragraph organized. Pointing to new ideas with these transition words also helps the reader understand why certain details are given.

First of all,
First,



(Image 1)

Second,
Secondly,



(Image 2)

Finally,



(Image 3)

✓ Practice 3C

The following paragraph is missing transitions in the body. Where should the transition word be? Put a star * where transitions are missing. Then rewrite the paragraph, adding the transitions.

Homemade Food

There are three main reasons why I like to eat homemade food. Homemade food doesn't cost too much. For example, I can buy fresh fish and vegetables at the grocery store for about \$15. This will feed my whole family. Homemade food is a lot healthier than precooked food. It contains only a few simple ingredients, and I don't cook it with too much salt or oil. Homemade food tastes better than precooked food. When I cook my own food, I follow traditional recipes and make it just right. For all of these reasons, I prefer to eat homemade food.

(recopy the paragraph with transitions here:)

The **conclusion sentence** is the last sentence of a one-paragraph essay. It is similar to the topic sentence because it:

- states the topic again
- *states the opinion or personal feeling again, sometimes in a stronger way (controlling idea)*

A conclusion sentence should NOT:

- be more than one sentence of the paragraph.
- introduce any new ideas.
- be exactly the same as the topic sentence.
- be a separate sentence that starts on a new line.

✖ Wrong

There are several reasons why I am studying at Washtenaw Community College. First, the tuition is very low. I can take college classes at WCC for less than half of the cost of a university class. Second, WCC has great teachers and student support. My teachers really care about their students. Class sizes are small, and lots of free tutoring is available. Finally, WCC is close to my house. I live only five miles from WCC, so I can ride the bus there in less than 20 minutes. I could even ride my bike there in nice weather.

For all of these reasons, I am taking classes at WCC.

Here are some words that can be used to start a topic sentence:

In conclusion, To conclude, In sum,

For all of these reasons, In all of these ways,

These are a few [qualities, things] that [S + V....]

✓ Practice 3D

This paragraph needs a conclusion sentence. Read the paragraph and choose the best one. Then copy your choice at the end of the paragraph. Be prepared to explain your choice.

Heather Zettelmaier

ESL 128

September 24, 2017

My Favorite Singer

My favorite singer is my husband, Jake. First of all, his music is traditional yet unique. He has a band called Black Jake and the Carnies, and they sing a special kind of music. It is a combination of bluegrass and punk, with instruments like the banjo, mandolin, drums, guitar, accordion, washboard, and even cow bell. Second, his music is full of fun and deep ideas. The words in the songs go very fast, and they usually tell a story and teach a lesson. I think my favorite song by Jake is "Happy Easter." This song tells a story of anger and forgiveness between neighbors and friends. It also talks about heaven and death, so it makes me think and touches my emotions. Finally, I like Jake as a singer because his songs make me want to smile, sing, and dance. He uses a funny voice, and it has great quality. It is so easy to catch onto the melodies and beats of his songs. I often clap, tap my foot, or even dance along.

- A. For all of these reasons, Jake Zettelmaier is my favorite singer.
- B. My husband Jake is a great singer, and I hope he and his band become more and more popular.
- C. There are many kinds of music, but my favorite kind is country music.

If your instructor asks you to write a **title** for your paragraph, there are rules that you should follow:

1. Use *capital letters* for the important words and the first word of the title. Don't use capital letters for prepositions (*of, for*), conjunctions (*and, or*), or articles (*the, a, an*).
2. Don't write a sentence. Don't end it with a period.
3. Write something short that gives the topic of your paragraph.

Look back at the titles in the sample paragraphs of this chapter. Do they all follow the rules for title writing?

Most timed, in-class paragraphs and essay test questions do NOT require a title. On the TOEFL test, for example, writing a title would be a poor use of your time. You should write a title for paragraphs that you write over a longer time, usually for homework.

What is the difference between a title and a topic sentence?

1. LOCATION:

A title is located _____.

A topic sentence is located _____.

2. CAPITAL LETTERS:

In a title, _____ should be capitalized.

In a topic sentence, only _____ should be capitalized.

3. GRAMMAR:

A title is NOT _____, so it doesn't end with a _____.

A topic sentence is _____, so it ends with a _____.

4. A title is only required for formal compositions, usually written over a long time. A topic sentence is ALWAYS needed in a paragraph.

✓ Practice 3E

Read the following titles. What is wrong with each one? Write a few words to explain. One of the titles is okay.

1. I want to visit Uzbekistan. OK NOT OK → Why? _____
2. My Paragraph OK NOT OK → Why? _____
3. Uzbekistan and Its Wonders OK NOT OK → Why? _____

Good writing doesn't happen instantly or without some careful thought. To write with quality, good writers follow three steps of the **writing process**:

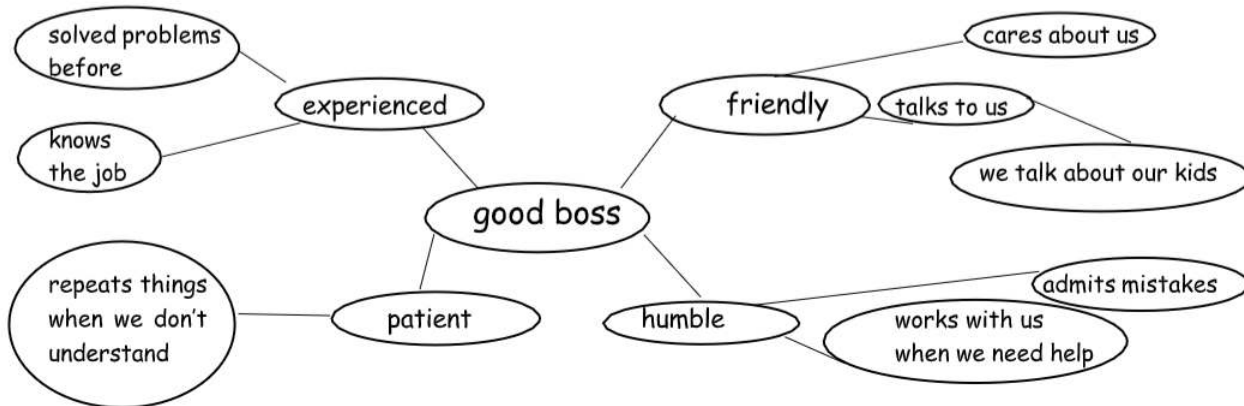
1. **Pre-writing.** In this step, *brainstorm*. In pre-writing, choose the best ideas and make a plan to organize the paragraph.
2. **Rough draft**, in other words, write the paragraph. Keep the ideas flowing. Try to write a good topic sentence and follow the plan from your pre-writing.
3. **Revise and edit.** Try to improve your paragraph. Make sure all of the sentences stay on topic. Check organization and work on the conclusion sentence. When you are sure the content is good, check the grammar.

In this book, we will practice several **pre-writing** strategies. The first one is called *clustering*.

Here is how it's done:

- write the topic in the middle of a page and circle it
- write about the topic in a general way, close to the middle word
- as you write farther away from the word, get more specific, add details
- *You do not have to include everything from your cluster in the paragraph.*

Topic: Write about the qualities of a good boss



✓ Practice 3F

Use the clustering method to brainstorm about one of the following topics. Use a separate sheet of paper.

Topic: Write about an interesting place near the city where you live now.

(example: near Ann Arbor, MI) Topic: Write about the qualities of a good teacher

Topic: Write about your favorite hobby or sport

Topic: Write about your favorite singer, athlete, writer, or actor

WRITING ASSIGNMENT:

Use one of the topics from Practice 3F to write a formal paragraph. Use the format rules on p. 8, Unit 1.

The **rough draft** can be written by hand. Please double space write in a single paragraph. Before you hand it in, check your paragraph:

- Does it have a title?
- How many sentences is it? (Try for 8-12. If it has less, try to find more information that fits your paragraph.)
- Does it have a topic sentence?
- Does it have a conclusion sentence?

The **rough draft** is due on . You will get feedback from your classmates and your instructor before writing the final draft. *Keep all pre-writing and rough drafts.*

The **final draft** will be due on . Your instructor will give you directions on the final draft.

Attributions

Image 1:

“Turn Left Arrow Road Sign Roadsign” is licensed via Pixabay under [CC0 1.0](#).

Image 2:

“Isolated Arrow Sign” by Paul Brennan is licensed via PublicDomainPictures.net under [CC0 1.0](#).

Image 3:

“Advisor Exit Speed English 34” by Ltljltlj via Wikimedia Commons is in the Public Domain.

This page titled [3: The Basics of Paragraphs](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

SECTION OVERVIEW

4: Routines and Opinions- Using the Simple Present

📌 The Weekend Cook



(Image 1)

My dad works in a bank. He works there from Monday to Friday. He helps people. He counts money, and he uses a computer. He is an important man at the bank. Dad also works at home. On weekends, he always cooks dinner. Usually he fixes Italian food. On Saturdays, he makes spaghetti. On Sundays, he makes pizza. Sometimes he fries chicken or fixes Chinese food. My mother watches and helps. She cuts the vegetables and tosses the salad. I wash the dishes. Some people say it is strange for a man to cook. My dad enjoys his hobby. Cooking relaxes him. His father was a weekend cook, too.

Underline all of the **verbs** in the paragraph above.

In each sentence, the **simple present verb tense** is used. Simple present is used for routines and general statements. Here are the basic forms of the simple present tense:

Singular Forms	Plural Forms
I like tomatoes. He / She / It likes tomatoes. You like tomatoes.	We like tomatoes. They like tomatoes.

Notice that *only the He / She / It* forms take an -s ending. This is called the **third person singular**. All other simple present verbs are simple – just the base form of the verb. They are formed with *one word*, no -s.

In “The Weekend Cook,” draw a  circle around the s in the simple present verbs. Why is an -s added in each case?

NOTES on IRREGULAR verbs: The verb *be* and *have* are irregular in the simple present.

<i>be</i> I am hungry. He / She / It is hungry. <u>You are hungry.</u> We are hungry. They are hungry.	<i>have</i> I have a car. He / She / It has a car. <u>You have a car.</u> We have a car. They have a car.
---	--

NOTES on SPELLING: A few verbs add -es in the third person singular. They are verbs that end in s, z, *sh*, *ch*, or x.

If a verb ends in a consonant and -y, change the y to *i* before adding -es. If the verb ends in a vowel and -y, simply add s.

✓ Practice 4A

Write the forms below with the correct spelling.

- He fixes (fix) He ____ (finish) He ____ (relax) He ____ (rush)
- She watches (watch) She ____ (toss) She ____ (wash) She ____ (miss) She ____ (teach)
- He tries (try) He ____ (fry) He ____ (study) He ____ (hurry) He ____ (carry)

4. She says (say) She ____ (enjoy) She ____ (play) She ____ (stay) She ____ (pay)

✓ Practice 4B

Rewrite the sentences below, adding the correct form of the verb. Remember that *he, she, and it* take -s forms.

1. Most women cook the dinners at home. (cook)
2. My mother cooks most of the time. (cook)
3. She ____ dinner on Mondays, Tuesdays, Wednesdays, and Thursdays. (make)
4. My father ____ Italian food on the weekends. (fix)
5. My brother and I ____ the dishes. (wash)
6. We ____ with the salad, too. (help)
7. I ____ to cook already. (know how)
8. Cooking ____ my father. (relax)
9. Many working people ____ (have) a lot of stress at work and (rush) around all day.
10. Often they ____ a hobby after work. (enjoy)

✓ Practice 4C

Write the sentences below and change all the singular nouns to plural nouns. You will not need an article before the plural noun. You will also need to change the verb forms from singular to plural.

1. A banker works with money.

Bankers work with money.

2. A pharmacist works with prescriptions.

3. A doctor eats a quick lunch.

4. A bank manager eats a long, slow lunch.

5. A pharmacist's assistant works in a pharmacy.

6. A good boy helps his family.

7. A father usually takes out the trash.

How do we make negative forms in the simple present tense? We add *don't* or *doesn't* before the base form of the verb.

Singular Forms	Plural Forms
I don't work. He / She / It doesn't work. You don't work.	We don't work. They don't work.

The negative forms of *be* are *am not*, *isn't*, and *aren't*.

✓ Practice 4D

Fill in the missing verb forms in this paragraph.

My Sister Liz

My sister Liz is a stay-at-home mom, but she is one of the busiest people I know. She _____ (1. have) two children, Sam and Beth. They _____ (2. be) both in middle school. Her husband Peter _____ (3. be) a doctor. He _____ (4. work) every day from 7 AM to 6 PM. Every morning during the week, my sister _____ (5. make) breakfast for Sam and Beth. The kids _____ (6. ride) the bus to school. During the day, Liz _____ (7. work) on projects for her small business. She _____ (8. sew) special orders from the Internet. She _____ (9. take) care of the house and _____ (10. prepare) meals. Sometimes she _____ (11. meet) friends for lunch or coffee. She _____ (12. take) their dog, Heidi, for walks. When Sam and Beth _____ (13. come) home, she _____ (14. give) them a snack and _____ (15. help) them with their homework. Liz _____ (16. make) dinner for everyone, but my brother-in-law Peter usually _____ (17. eat) late, after 7 PM. She _____ (18. sit) with him while he (19. eat). At their church, she _____ (20. volunteer) with children and _____ (21. sing) in the choir. My sister _____ (22. not, have) a job, but she always seems very busy to me.

✓ Practice 4E

Choose a family member or friend that you know very well. On a separate piece of paper, write a journal about this person's routine. You can include information about their work, family, hobbies, and other habits. Write in correct paragraph format.

Write the person's name in the first sentence.

In Unit 3, you learned a **pre-writing technique** called clustering. Another pre-writing technique is **making a list**. When you make a list for pre-writing, write down every word that comes to mind when you hear a topic. Don't worry about spelling or separating main ideas from detail. Do not write sentences.

Here is an example of *making a list* pre-writing for the topic, "My Favorite Season."

📌 Summer

warm
sunny
long days
vacation
no school
travel
ice cream
swim
lakes

Up North
camping
reading
sleeping later
festivals
my family visits
green leaves
blue skies
neighborhood kids out playing

The writer might find two or three "big" ideas in the list and make a plan for the paragraph. In this case, the writer might focus on:

1. Warm weather
 - sunny
 - walks, neighbors come out
 - swim
2. no school
 - free time to read

- play with kids
- travel and camp

TOPIC SENTENCE: Summer is my favorite season for several reasons.

✓ Practice 4F

On a separate piece of paper, practice making a list about two of these topics:

- my favorite city, or a city I know well - my favorite website
- my favorite holiday - my favorite store or shopping center
- my favorite restaurant - my favorite tourist destination
- a job I am interested in, reasons why

✓ Practice 4G

Choose ONE of your lists from Practice 4F. Make a short plan for a formal paragraph. Then write a topic sentence for the paragraph.

This paragraph will include many reasons that an item is your favorite, or one of your favorites. When we give reasons, we often need to use the connecting word **because**.

Because can come at the beginning of the sentence. Then it needs to be followed by a comma and a main clause (main S V O). More often, *because* comes in the middle of the sentence with *no comma*.

CORRECT: Because it has a diverse population, Ann Arbor is one of my favorite cities. Ann Arbor is one of my favorite cities because it has a diverse population.

INCORRECT: Because it has a diverse population. Ann Arbor is one of my favorite cities. INCORRECT: Ann Arbor is one of my favorite cities. Because it has a diverse population. INCORRECT: Ann Arbor is one of my favorite cities, because it has a diverse population. INCORRECT: Ann Arbor is one of my favorite cities, Because it has a diverse population. INCORRECT: Ann Arbor is one of my favorite cities. Because, it has a diverse population. RULE: **NO COMMA BEFORE BECAUSE** when it comes in the middle of a sentence.

✓ Practice 4H

Connect the two sentences. Use *because*. Example:

I like Facebook. It lets me see photos of everyone's children.

I like Facebook because it lets me see photos of everyone's children.

1. I enjoy the Lunar New Year. The whole family gets together.
2. Great Lakes Crossing is my favorite mall. It has two great attractions for my kids.
3. I recommend visiting Washington, DC. It has great museums.
4. Machu Picchu is a very popular tourist destination. It has amazing views of ancient ruins.
5. I recommend Bell's Diner if you like Korean food. They have great bibimbap.

✓ Practice 4I

Write the rough draft of a paragraph using the topic, list, plan, and topic sentence that you worked on in Practice 4F and 4G. Your paragraph should include:

- a topic sentence in the paragraph at the beginning
- 8-12 sentences of supporting details and examples
- a conclusion sentence
- a title

Your instructor will give you specific deadlines for the rough draft and the revision of this paragraph.

Try to read and respond to a classmate's paragraph. When you get feedback from your classmate and instructor, write the **final draft** of this paragraph.

The *simple present tense* is used to *write a summary of a novel or other work of fiction*. Using the simple present tense in this way is called the **narrative present**.

✓ Practice 4J

Your instructor will ask you to write a summary of a chapter or two of a book that you are reading. Choose ONE CHARACTER from the book. Write 5 sentences about what happened to that character in those chapters. Use the narrative present. Use the –s ending for third person subjects.

Example:

In Chapter 3, Billy wakes up and finds out that his grandpa is very sick. He runs through the snow to the doctor's house.

He wakes up the doctor.

Billy and the doctor run back to help Grandpa.

Billy tells the doctor about Grandpa's heart problem.

Attributions

This Unit, through Practice 4C is from:

"Developing Writing: Writing Skills Practice Book for EFL" by Patricia Wilcox Peterson, Office of English Language Programs, U.S. Department of State is in the Public Domain

Image 1:

"Active cooking at Foodlab Stockholm" by K.I.T. is licensed via Flickr under [CC BY 2.0](#).

This page titled [4: Routines and Opinions- Using the Simple Present](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Heather Zettelmaier](#) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

SECTION OVERVIEW

5: Narrative Writing- Using the Simple Past

The following paragraph tells a story that happened in the past. Such a paragraph is called **narrative writing**. Narrative writing tells a story in detail.



(Image 1)

📌 Lessons from a Fire

In 2001, something difficult happened to me, and I learned many lessons from it. While I was in St. Louis at a conference, I got a phone call from my landlady. She told me that there was a fire in my apartment building in Ypsilanti. Everything was damaged, but nobody was hurt. I was shocked by this news. A few hours later, someone from my church called to tell me that a close friend had just died. I knew I had to go home, see my burned home, and attend a very sad funeral. I usually don't talk to people on airplanes, but on the flight home, I told the woman sitting next to me about my bad news. Indeed, when I got home, my apartment was blackened with smoke damage. I stayed with a friend of mine and borrowed some clothes. The next day, I went to the funeral and mourned with my friends. At my church, I found six or seven bags of things that someone left for me: dishes, canned food, towels, clothes, and even some gift cards. In one of the cards, it said, "Good luck! Michelle." I thought these gifts were from my friends, but I didn't have any friends named Michelle. Then I realized who it was from. All of the stuff was from the woman on the airplane. This hard time taught me how good people can be, and how important it is to be generous to strangers at just the right time.

✓ Practice 5A

Read the paragraph "Lessons from a Fire" and follow these instructions. Discuss your answers with a partner.

1. Look at the *topic sentence*. What is the topic and opinion/feeling?
2. Now look at the conclusion sentence. How are they similar? How are they different?
3. Underline all of the *simple past verbs* in the paragraph.
4. Circle  the commas. How many commas are used because of the words "but" and "and"? Why are the other commas used?

The **simple past** verb tense is used to write about events that happened in the past and are complete. Simple past is an easy choice when the time of the event is given by some time expression. Here are some examples of past time expressions:

in [2012]
yesterday
[two years, three months, a long time] ago
this morning

in [May]
on [May 19, 2012]
last [night, week, month, year]
When I [was a child]...

Regular verbs take an *-ed* ending to form the past tense. The spelling rules depend on the spelling and syllable stress of the verb.

1. Most regular verbs simply take *-ed*.

Examples: She worked. He turned left.

2. Verbs that end with *e* simply add *-d*.

Examples: We danced. We lived.

3. *Verbs that end with a vowel (V) + y, just add -ed. Verbs that end with consonant (C) + y, drop the y and add ied.*

Examples: They enjoyed the party. She carried the suitcase.

4. For one-syllable verbs that end V C, double the consonant. For one-syllable verbs that end with V C V, don't double the consonant.

VC VCV

stop hope

We stopped for gas. They hoped to get a green card.

5. For two-syllable verbs that end with VC, double the consonant if the stress is on the second syllable. Do not double the consonant if the stress is on the first syllable.

VC (stress second syllable) VC (stress first syllable)

conTROL LISten

My boss controlled me. I listened to my boss.

✓ Practice 5B

Write the simple past verbs in the blanks. Use the correct spelling.



(Image 2)

1. We (move) last year.
2. I (study) architecture.
3. Jasmin (wait) a long time for her visa.
4. They (save) a lot of money by using Craigslist.
5. She (chop) vegetables for the soup.
6. We (love) the movie that we saw last night.
7. Tom (admit) that he was in love with Beth.
8. Something scary (happen) to me in 2016.
9. Last year, I (open) a bank account at PNC Bank.
10. I (travel) a lot when I was a student.

Many verbs in English have *irregular past tense forms*. In the paragraph “Lessons from a Fire,” find the past tense forms of the following verbs. Write them next to the present tense forms.

PRESENT	PAST	PRESENT	PAST
am		have	
is		go	
are		find	
get		leave	
tell		say	
know		think	
		teach	

Here are the negative forms of the simple past:

I *didn't* have time to say goodbye. She / He / It *didn't* work.

You *didn't* work.

We *didn't* have time to say goodbye. They *didn't* have time to say goodbye.

EXCEPTION: *be* verb I *wasn't* hungry.

She / He / It *wasn't* hungry. You *weren't* hungry.

We *weren't* hungry

They *weren't* hungry.

✓ Practice 5C

Rewrite the sentences using the simple past.

1. My grandma has heart surgery last winter.
2. The doctors work for three hours.
3. I visit my grandma in the hospital.
4. I take her flowers and a good book.
5. We aren't sure how the surgery goes.
6. Five days after the surgery, Grandma leaves the hospital.
7. She makes a full recovery.
8. In fact, she has more energy after the surgery.

✓ Practice 5D

Fill in the tense verbs in the following paragraph.

Good Bye, Yellow Kite

When I was about seven years old, my family had (1. have) an interesting hobby: flying kites. My dad ____ (2. buy) a lot of kites. Some kites ____ (3. be) cut in special shapes or had interesting pictures on them. My sister and I ____ (4. tie) long tails and ribbons on our kites. My favorite kite ____ (5. be) a secondhand yellow kite with a red tail. One very windy day, my dad ____ (6. drive) us to a park with a big hill. We all ____ (7. fly) our kites in the strong wind on the top of the hill. I ____ (8. let) out my string all the way and ____ (9. hold) on tightly. I couldn't even see the kite! When it was time to go, I ____ (10. pull) on my string, but I just couldn't bring that kite in. My dad ____ (11. try) to help me, but the wind just ____ (12. keep) pulling the kite, almost out of our hands. Finally, my dad ____ (13. cut) the string and let the kite go. I ____ (14. be) so upset that I ____ (15. throw) myself down on the ground and cried. My family laughs now at my strong emotions. For me as a little girl, saying goodbye to my yellow kite was a very sad experience.

✓ Practice 5E

Tell a story to a small group. If you can't think of something that happened to you, tell the story of a friend or family member. When you speak, pay attention to your simple past verbs.

Choose one of these, or just talk about something that you remember well.

1. something that happened that made you very happy
2. a birthday you remember well
3. the story of your journey to the U.S.
4. how you met your spouse (or how you got engaged)
5. a time you got into trouble as a child, or a time you were in trouble with the police
6. problems you had with animals
7. a great or terrible vacation
8. a time when someone helped you, or you helped someone else
9. a time when a major political event touched your life
10. a time when a natural disaster touched your life

TO THE LISTENERS: Write down the past tense verbs that you hear during the story. Write at least five of the verbs that they use.

In Unit 1, we learned that normal English word order in sentences is:

S	V	O	P	T
subject	verb	object	place	time
Mike	bought	his first car	in Michigan	last year.

In narrative paragraphs, the “T,” or *time expressions*, are often used as a **transition words** in the paragraph. That is, they are at the front of the sentence to show the **chronological order**, or time order, of the story. When the time expression is at the beginning of the sentence, a comma separates it from the S V O in the sentence. Note these examples from “Lessons from a Fire”:

In 2001, something difficult happened to me, and I learned many lessons from it. **While I was in St. Louis at a conference**, I got a phone call from my landlady. [...] **A few hours later**, someone from my church called to tell me that a close friend had just died. [...] **The next day**, I went to the funeral and mourned with my friends. [...]

Prepositions are often used to express place and time. Here are some examples. What's the rule? Discuss with your classmates and instructor.

PLACE

Examples	Rule/Pattern
My friend lives <i>in</i> this apartment building. Helen spends a lot of time <i>in</i> her room.	<i>in</i> +
I can't talk right now. I'm <i>at</i> work. We arrived <i>at</i> the airport, but our suitcase didn't. I enjoy studying <i>at</i> coffee shops. The barber shop is <i>at</i> 408 Main Street.	<i>at</i> +
The barber shop <i>in</i> on Main Street. The computer lab is <i>on</i> the second floor of the GM building. Please don't sing <i>on</i> the elevator.	<i>on</i> +

TIME

Examples	Rule/Pattern
Jose moved <i>in</i> June. I'm going to start taking photography classes <i>in</i> the winter. My daughter was born <i>in</i> 2009. He always drinks coffee <i>in</i> the morning.	<i>in</i> +
Class begins <i>at</i> 11:00. She loves to read <i>at</i> night.	<i>at</i> +
My interview is <i>on</i> Tuesday. My daughter was born <i>on</i> May 8, 2009. <i>On</i> New Year's Eve, we set off fireworks.	<i>on</i> +

✓ Practice 5F

Add the correct prepositions. Add commas where necessary.

1. My flight arrived 4:00 PM December 28, 2009.
2. night eight inches of snow fell.
3. I was surprised when I woke up the morning.
4. January it snowed more than six inches every week.
5. Finally the flowers started blooming the end of April.
6. When spring came we spent almost every evening the park.

So far, we have been looking at *simple sentences* with our S V O word order patterns. A **compound sentence** is slightly longer. It is made up of two simple sentences connected with a coordinating conjunction. The seven coordinating conjunctions are **for, and, nor, but, or, yet, and so** (known by the acronym: FANBOYS). The function of the conjunction is to determine the relationship between the two simple sentences.

📌 Note

Note that the most common coordinating conjunctions used in writing are *and, but, and so*.

Conjunction	Meaning/Use	Example
For:	In this situation, it means <i>because</i> . (formal, not common)	He dropped the class, for he was too busy.
And:	<i>And</i> is used to show addition. It's like a "+" sign in the middle of the sentence. (VERY COMMON)	Our friends came over for dinner, and we enjoyed our time together.
Nor:	<i>Nor</i> connects two negative facts. The word order is unusual. (formal, not common)	My boss didn't take New Year's Day off, nor did he take a vacation this year.
But:	This is used to show <i>contrast</i> or to show <i>unexpected result</i> . (VERY COMMON)	My sister loves to shop, but I hate shopping. It was raining, but we didn't cancel the picnic.
Or:	This is used to show two choices. (not common)	Passengers can get a cabin with a view, or they can choose a big inside cabin.
Yet:	This use is similar to <i>but</i> , used for unexpected result. <i>Yet</i> is a little stronger and more formal. (not common)	Tim is very quiet, yet he has many friends.
So:	<i>So</i> is used to show a logical result. (VERY COMMON)	It was raining, so we canceled the picnic.

✓ Practice 5G

Below are compound sentences that contain *two* simple sentences.

- Find and label the S V O.
- Circle ○ the coordinating conjunction.

Then add three of your own sentences using three different coordinating conjunctions.

1. Pamela bought some new dishes, and she gave her old ones to Jill.
2. Karen and Greg went to Tennessee last week, so they didn't go to the party.
3. Frank has a new job, but he misses his old one.
4. Jack made dinner for Jill last night, but she couldn't eat it.
5. Kacie is getting married, so she has a lot to do.
6. _____
7. _____
8. _____

✓ Practice 5H

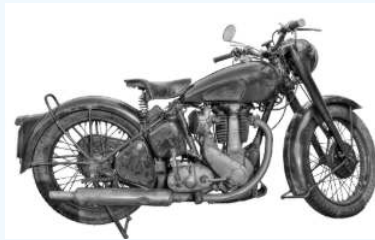
Put the pairs of sentences together using a logical coordinating conjunction (FANBOYS). Remember that if you join two sentences together using a coordinating conjunction, you must use a comma (,) in between them. Use both complete sentences to maintain the writer's original meaning. Use pronouns when possible.

1. Mary doesn't drink coffee. Mary doesn't drink beer. Mary doesn't drink coffee, and she doesn't drink beer.
2. Ali's team won first place in the district. Ali's team might win the state finals.
3. Kris likes volleyball. Kris doesn't like bowling.
4. Ben is looking for a new job. Ben knows his company is moving out of the state.
5. Would you like to go out for dinner? Would you like to stay home and cook?
6. I have been saving my money for two years. Now I can buy a new car.
7. Mike has been learning Spanish for seven years. Mike has never visited a Spanish-speaking country.
8. Filling out applications is important. You must also call store managers.

9. Many students like ESL grammar classes. Many students do not like ESL writing classes.
10. Jennifer doesn't like her new job. Jennifer doesn't want to go back to her old job.
11. Felipe doesn't like his job. Felipe knows he must keep his job.
12. We have a preposition quiz tomorrow. We had better study.
13. We can get the car fixed. We can buy a new car.
14. Sandy takes night classes during the week. Sandy works at Bagel Barn on weekends.

✓ Practice 5I

Below are compound sentences that contain TWO clauses. Find the S V O and label them.



(Image 3)

1. Jack has a dog, and it had puppies.
2. Jena is a pre-school teacher, so she needs a lot of patience.
3. Tom is going to buy a new motorcycle because his other one needs too much work.
4. Although Brian lives in Iowa, he still visits his family every weekend.
5. Kelly is going to quit her job when she has a baby.
6. David will take you to the airport if you need a ride.
7. Larry asked Melanie if she wanted to go to the parade.
8. I have a lot of homework, but I have no time to do it.
9. Juan has a full-time job, so he can only take two classes per semester.

✓ Practice 5J

Choose ONE of the topics below for your narrative paragraph.

1. Write the story of something that happened to you in a paragraph. It can be something sad, happy, frightening, funny, important, difficult, or embarrassing. Use the pre-writing (speaking) activity from Practice 5E if you need more ideas.
2. Write a narrative paragraph called "My Best Day." Write a true story about the best day of your life.
3. Write a narrative paragraph called "A Time I was Afraid." Write a true story about a time that you were afraid.

Your instructor will let you know when to submit the rough draft and final draft. When you finish your rough draft, look back at the ways to create compound sentences using

- and
- but
- so

Read your paragraph one more time. Did you use *and*, *but*, or *so*? Did you use them correctly?

Do you have a lot of short sentences? Can you combine a few of them using *and*, *but*, or *so*?

✓ Practice 5K

Help the writers with their simple past verbs. Add the *be* verb where necessary.

1. I had an accident. There is no major damage to the car.
2. It was a long flight. I try to find something to do, but it still boring and I couldn't sleep.

3. I didn't asked him, "How are you?"
4. That's when I toled her what hapen.
5. I make my way to Italy across the sea, but because of a heavy storm, I end up in Malta instead of Italy.

In Unit 2, we practiced writing in the simple present to summarize. The narrative present (simple present) is used to write a summary of a fictional story. However, if you are writing a summary of a nonfiction text that informs about history, use past tenses. Examples of nonfiction articles about history are biographies and true stories about historical events.

The following passage is from "Daily Life in Ancient China: Social Class, Clothing, and Adornments" by Emily Mark. Read the text. Then read the summary that follows.



(Image 4)

During the period known as the Five Dynasties and Ten Kingdoms (907-960 CE) the practice of foot binding began. It probably started earlier but became a custom after the reign of the emperor Li Yu (937-978 CE) who had his consort Yia Niang bind her feet to resemble a crescent moon and perform a special dance for guests at one of his parties. Li Yu had erected a large golden statue of a lotus flower in his garden, and Yia Niang's dance was to honor its unveiling. Her dance was so beautiful it made the other women there want feet as tiny and graceful as Yia Niang's were, and soon the idea developed that a beautiful woman should have tiny feet.

Girls as young as toddlers would have their feet wrapped in bandages so tightly it broke their toes and curled them under the foot. Girls had to walk around stepping on their own toes and were in constant pain for years until they grew used to it. Although this practice started among the upper classes, it soon became common for all women in China. This made working in the rice fields or doing any kind of manual labor very difficult. Women are shown in ancient paintings crawling in the rice paddies because they could not walk. Foot binding continued for centuries until it was outlawed in 1911 CE. Many women were interviewed in the late 19th early 20th centuries CE on footbinding and talked about crying from the pain for years and how it never made them feel any more beautiful.

Summary

According to "Daily Life in China: Social Class, Clothing, and Adornments," a famous beautiful woman named Yia Niang started the practice of footbinding in the 900s. For hundreds of years, the feet of young girls were wrapped tightly to make them small and beautiful. This was very painful. Many girls cried and worked in pain. Footbinding ended in the 20th century.

✓ Practice 5L

Find a nonfiction text about something historical in your reading textbook, or choose a book about history from the library. Write a summary of the text. Use past tense verbs when necessary.

Attributions

"Daily Life in Ancient China" by Emily Mark, [Adapted by Lumen Learning](#) is licensed under [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#) / A derivative from the [original work](#)

Image 1:

“Greenfield Apartment Fire” by Jay Adan is licensed via Flickr under [CC BY 2.0](#).

Image 2:

“Architecture Students (5118908560)” by Tulane Public Relations is licensed via Wikimedia Commons under [CC BY 2.0](#).

Image 3:

“Bsa Motorcycle Oldtimer Old Motorcycle Vehicle” by Emslichter is licensed via Pixabay under [CC0 1.0](#).

Image 4:

“GebundenerFuss” by Ernst v. Hesse-Wartegg is licensed via Wikimedia Commons under [Public Domain Mark 1.0](#).

This page titled [5: Narrative Writing- Using the Simple Past](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Heather Zettelmaier](#) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

SECTION OVERVIEW

6: Supporting Opinions with Reasons

It is important to be able to express your opinion and support it with facts, details, and explanations. In American college classes, instructors will often ask you to “take a stand” and give reasons for your opinion. It is not so important that your opinion be the same as the instructor or your classmates. A strong writer will have strong, detailed, well-expressed support.

In this unit, we will write paragraphs that **list reasons**. Reasons are used to answer the question “Why?” You might be asked to explain a behavior using your observations and experiences. You may also be asked to agree or disagree with a statement and explain why you think that way.



(Image 1)

✓ Practice 6A

Speak with a partner about the following statements. One of you *must* agree with each statement. The other person *must* disagree with the statement. Decide which of you will agree and disagree. Discuss the statement. Give reasons for your opinion. Use details and examples from your life experience and thinking. Try to speak for at least 3 minutes about each statement.

1. Boys and girls should attend separate schools.
2. Growing up in a big family is better than growing up in a small family.
3. Online classes are better than traditional classes taught in person.
4. Watching TV is a great way to learn English.

Pre-writing is useful for getting ideas and organizing them. So far, we have used two methods of pre-writing: clustering and making a list. A very efficient method of both brainstorming and organizing at the same time is making a **rough outline**. With this method, write your more general ideas to the left. On the next line, indent a little and put a bullet point next to a supporting idea. The farther to the right, the more specific your details should be.

Here is an example of a rough outline for the *Why*- question, “Why do some people choose not to get married?”

Not get married because:

- haven’t found right person
 - want perfect partner, ideal, waiting
 - Sharon: list
- choose career
 - demanding, stress, time
 - journalist, movies
 - satisfaction
- freedom

- travel, move
 - Siska
- make choices for self

✓ Practice 6B

Choose TWO of the questions below. Write a rough outline as pre-writing. Be prepared to share your ideas with the class.

1. Why do people exercise? Write a paragraph that lists three reasons. Plan your support.
2. Is it better to grow up in a big family or a small family? Why do you think so? Give three reasons. Plan your support.
3. Is it better to get married when you are young (17-22), or should people wait until they are older (27 and up)? Why do you think so? Give three reasons. Plan your support.
4. Do you prefer to spend your free time outside or inside? Give reasons.
5. Many American high school students have a part-time job. Is this a good thing or a bad thing? Why do you think so? Give three reasons for your opinion. Plan your support.

The *topic sentence* of a reasons paragraph should show the reader that you will discuss reasons. If you are supporting an opinion, the opinion should be clear in the topic sentence. Remember, a paragraph *starts with the topic sentence*. There should be only ONE sentence before you begin your first reason.

✓ Practice 6C

In each pair, which is the better topic sentence for a reasons paragraph? Discuss your choices with a partner.

1. A. I enjoy living in Ann Arbor for several reasons.
B. I came to Ann Arbor in 2009, and I was surprised by how friendly the people were.
2. A. Some people like to live in the city. Other people think the country is a nicer place to raise a family.
B. There are several reasons why it is better to live in the country than in the city.
3. A. I would prefer to take classes online for a few reasons.
B. Nowadays, online classes are very popular. My friend got his degree online. I want to take online classes, too.

It is normal to use *for a few reasons*, *for several reasons*, or *for three reasons* in a topic sentence that will list reasons. Some writers can easily name the main idea of each reason in their topic sentences like this:

I enjoy living in Ann Arbor because of its diverse population, good educational opportunities, and green spaces.

Notice that *because of* is a preposition. It is followed by a list of nouns.

I enjoy living in Ann Arbor because it has a diverse population, good educational opportunities, and green spaces.

Notice that *because* starts a new clause. That is, it will need S V O.

✓ Practice 6D

Fix the grammar in the following topic sentences.

1. There are some reason that I am studying English.
2. Florida is a great place to take a vacation, I go there for several reasons.
3. Working at a restaurant was difficult because the schedule, the customers, and the walking.
4. I want to travel to China because of it has good shopping, great food, and famous historical places.
5. I believe that high school student should not have a job for few reason.

In Unit 3, we noticed that *transition words* help the reader follow a well-organized paragraph. Here is a list of some transition words that we have already used, and some new ones:

for the first reason: First, First of all, The first reason is [NOUN phrase] The first reason is that [S V O]	Examples: First, WCC has great teachers. First of all, WCC has great teachers. The first reason is the great teachers at WCC. The first reason is that WCC has great teachers.
for the second reason: Second, Secondly, The second reason is [NOUN phrase] The second reason is that [S V O]	Examples: Second, WCC has low tuition. Secondly, WCC has low tuition. The second reason is the low tuition at WCC. The second reason is that WCC has low tuition.
for the last reason: Finally, The last reason is [NOUN phrase] The last reason is that [S V O]	Examples: Finally, WCC has beautiful facilities. The last reason is WCC's beautiful facilities. The last reason is that WCC has beautiful facilities.
for examples: For example, For instance, [...], such as [...]. [...], for example, [...].	Examples: For example, the library is large and comfortable. For instance, the library is large and comfortable. There are beautiful places to walk, such as the Fitness Center and Community Park. There are beautiful places to walk, for example, the Fitness Center and Community Park.
for conclusions: In conclusion, To conclude, In sum, For all of these reasons, Because of [Nouns], S V O	Examples: In conclusion, WCC is a great choice for my English studies. To conclude, WCC is a great choice for my English studies. In sum, WCC is a great choice for my English studies. For all of these reasons, WCC is a great choice for my English studies. Because of its teachers, tuition, and facilities, WCC is a great choice for my English studies.

✓ Practice 6E

Read the following paragraph. It is based on the rough outline example from earlier in this unit. Answer the questions that follow.

Some people decide not to get married for several reasons. First of all, maybe these people didn't meet the right person to marry. For example, my friend Sharon wants to marry someone who is smart, handsome, rich, and kind. She wants to wait until she falls in love with this perfect man, so she hasn't gotten married yet, and she is now 58 years old. Secondly, some people think getting married will take their focus away from their career. Some jobs require traveling or long hours at work. For instance, movie directors and journalists often have to travel for long periods of time, so marriage is difficult for those people. Finally, some people don't get married because they want total freedom. If you stay single, you can quit your job, move, date, and try many things without thinking of another person. For all of these reasons, some people decide not to get married.

1. What is the topic sentence? Underline it.
2. Underline the *transition words* that lead from one reason to the next.
3. Underline the conclusion sentence.

✓ Practice 6F

The following are general reasons for paragraphs. Each reason needs more support. Add sentences with details or examples for each.

1. (for a paragraph about “Why do people have pets?”)

Topic sentence: There are several reasons why people get a pet.

REASON 1: First of all, people get pets if they are lonely.

SUPPORT:

REASON 2: Second, people get pets for exercise.

SUPPORT:

2. (for a paragraph about “Why do people listen to music?”)

Topic sentence: People listen to music for many reasons.

REASON 1: One reason is that music helps people stay happy while they do boring tasks.

SUPPORT:

REASON 2: Another reason is that music helps people have fun.

SUPPORT:

REASON 3: Finally, people listen to music to relax.

SUPPORT:

✓ Practice 6G

In the following paragraph, the general reasons are missing. Only the details are given. Write the general reason. Remember to use transition words.

Getting There: Drive or Fly?



(Image 2) (Image 3)

When I take a vacation, I prefer to fly rather than drive. _____ . For example, driving to Florida takes 24 hours. It is impossible to drive straight through, especially if my children are coming. On the other hand, flying to Florida takes only three hours. _____ . For instance, if I drive to New York City, I will have to pay a lot for parking the whole time. However, if I fly, I will be able to enjoy the subway and train system without worrying about my car. _____ . There are far more car accidents than plane accidents. My safety while driving depends on many things: other drivers, the weather, the road, my tiredness. Flying is kind of worry-free for me in terms of safety. For all of these reasons, I would rather fly than drive to my vacation spot whenever possible.

✓ Practice 6H

The following sentences belong in one paragraph about reasons. First, put the sentences in logical order. Put a “1” next to the first sentence, a “2” next to the second sentence, and so on. Then write the paragraph on the lines below.

Question: Why do people get college degrees?

_____ These people might major in art, philosophy, or other social sciences, but they don’t know what job they want.

_____ Finally, some people get a college degree because of pressure from other people.

_____ Maybe their parents want them to get a college degree, or all of their friends are getting a degree.

_____ Second, some people get a college degree to show that they are educated.

_____ For example, if you want to become a teacher, a lawyer, or an engineer, the first step is getting a college degree.

_____ There are many reasons why people get college degrees.

_____ They just want to learn, discuss things, and develop their minds in college.

_____ All of these are reasons that people go to college and get degrees.

_____ Many jobs require a higher education.

_____ These people might not have their own reason to get a degree, but they choose to get one anyway.

_____ First, people get college degrees because they want to get a good job.

What verb tense is used in the paragraph about “Why do people get a college degree?”

Remember, the *simple present* is used to make general statements. Other verb forms are used as needed. Examples about past experiences usually use *simple past*. Gerunds and infinitives might be found in sentences as subjects and objects. (See Appendix C.)

✓ Practice 6I

Use one of your rough outlines from PRACTICE 6B. Write the rough draft of your paragraph for this topic. Double space your paragraph. Bring your paragraph to class for a peer review and feedback from your instructor.

Paragraphs about reasons often give support by showing a result. Imagine you are writing a paragraph about reasons that you would like to take online classes. You will need to give support with results:

I would like to take online classes because I live far away from WCC. I live far away from WCC, so I would like to take online classes.

I live over one hour from WCC. It is very hard for me to come to campus. As a result, I would like to take online classes.

Notice the punctuation of the sentences above. Here is a summary of the types of words that connect causes and effects:

Grammatical Term	Example	Rules to Remember
Coordinating Conjunction	The weather is terrible in Ann Arbor, so I dislike living here.	Put a comma before <i>so</i> . Don't start a sentence with <i>so</i> . Don't put a comma after it.
Subordinating Conjunction	I dislike living in Ann Arbor <i>because</i> the weather is terrible.	NO COMMA BEFORE BECAUSE
Two-word preposition	I dislike living in Ann Arbor <i>because of</i> the terrible weather.	No comma, No SVO after <i>because of</i> , just a noun or noun phrase
Transition word or phrase	Ann Arbor has long, cold winters and hot, humid summers. <i>As a result</i> , I dislike living here.	Usually starts a sentence. Capital letter followed by a comma. Other examples: <i>Therefore, Thus.</i>

✓ Practice 6J

Practice using the three ways to connect causes and effects. Use the word in parentheses.

1. The movie has great actors. Watching it is a very emotional experience. (so)
2. My boss is very kind and flexible. Working for him is a pleasure. (as a result)
3. I avoid watching the news. It is depressing and confusing. (because)
4. I liked this book. It had amazing photos. (because of)

✓ Practice 6K

Choose a book that you have read for this class. Write a short paragraph about why you liked or didn't like the book. Your topic sentence should state your opinion and the title of the book. Underline the book's title.

Example topic sentence: I liked Jane Eyre for many reasons.

Support your opinion with reasons. Remember that if you are summarizing parts of a fiction book, use *simple present* (narrative present: see Unit 4).

In the conclusion sentence of your paragraph, write whether or not you would recommend the book to others. Be specific if you think only some people would like it.

Example conclusion sentence: Jane Eyre is a wonderful book, and I recommend it to everyone. OR Pele is a great book, and I recommend it for soccer fans.

Attributions

Image 1:

"Good question" by Eric is licensed via Flickr under [CC BY-ND 2.0](#). Image 2:

"Car Driving Blue Vehicle Transportation Drive" by Clker-Free-Vector-Images / 29595 images is licensed via Pixabay under [CC0 1.0](#).

Image 3:

"Airplane Jet Plane Red Flying Aircraft Aeroplane" by Clker-Free-Vector-Images / 29595 images is licensed via Pixabay under [CC0 1.0](#).

This page titled [6: Supporting Opinions with Reasons](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Heather Zettelmaier](#) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

2: Appendix

- 2.1: Appendix A- List of Frequently Misspelled Words
- 2.2: Appendix B- Personal Spelling List and Practice
- 2.3: Appendix C- Gerund Subjects and Non-referential (“dummy”) It
- 2.4: Appendix D- Plural Agreement and Basic Article Use

This page titled [2: Appendix](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Heather Zettelmaier](#) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

2.1: Appendix A- List of Frequently Misspelled Words

Words frequently misspelled in low intermediate writing:

first
daughter
who / how
homework
affect / effect
question
because
friend
finally
every day / everyday
conclusion
a lot
by / pay
fun / fan
responsibility
would
example
health
beautiful
experience
second
writing
believe
grammar
addition
neighbor

Add to the list, class words:

✓ Practice 1A

I belive that children can learn alot by using technology. Frist, using apps and learning Web sites makes learning more fan for children. For exampel, my dohter does her spelling homworke on a spelling Web site once a week. It's easy for her to by attention becous of the colorful graphics in the activities. Secound, technology often challenges children while they learn. Many learning programs give kids harder qeustions if they get the easy ones right. Finaly, by using technology, children also get experence with equipment like a computer keyboard and mouse. Children how practice these skills are able to use technology for many things in their lives. In conlution, technology can be a very useful learning tool for children.

Write the misspelled words from this paragraph one more time – correctly!

1.	6.	11.
2.	7.	12.
3.	8.	13.
4.	9.	14.
5.	10.	15.

This page titled [2.1: Appendix A- List of Frequently Misspelled Words](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Heather Zettelmaier](#) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

2.2: Appendix B- Personal Spelling List and Practice

When you get your writing back with corrections, write down the words that you spelled incorrectly. Follow these instructions:

1. Write the word incorrectly, as you wrote it first.
2. Make a big “X” through the incorrectly spelled word.
3. Spell the word correctly.
4. Find a way to remember the correct spelling. This could be:
 - Break the word into small parts
 - Develop a memory trick, any easy way for you to remember the spelling
 - Remember a word that rhymes with it that has easy spelling
 - Understand the history of the word and its spelling
5. On the right, under “PRACTICE,” write the word four or five times. Say the word out loud each time that you write it.

Misspelled Word	Correctly Spelled	How can I remember this word's spelling?	PRACTICE Write the word at least four times. Say it out loud.
finaly	finally	<i>final</i> has an “l” already. It’s an adverb, so we need to add <i>ly</i> , so 2 <i>ls</i> are needed	finally finally finally finally

This page titled [2.2: Appendix B- Personal Spelling List and Practice](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Heather Zettelmaier](#) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

2.3: Appendix C- Gerund Subjects and Non-referential (“dummy”) It

A **gerund** is the *-ing* form of a verb. Grammatically, it functions as a **noun** in a sentence. That is, it can be a Subject, Object, or Object of a Preposition.

Watching sports is fun for me. (gerund as Subject) I enjoy working outside. (gerund as Object)

She is not interested in learning how to sew. (gerund as Object of a Preposition)

✓ Practice 1C

Underline all of the *-ing* forms. Which of these sentences contain gerunds? If you circle “has a gerund,” also check what grammatical role the gerund is playing in the sentence.

Example: <u>Taking</u> care of a pet can be expensive.	No gerund	Has a gerund ☒ Subject ☐ Object ☐ Object of preposition
1. I spend a lot of time surfing the internet.	No gerund	Has a gerund ☐ Subject ☐ Object ☐ Object of preposition
2. I am taking two classes this semester.	No gerund	Has a gerund ☐ Subject ☐ Object ☐ Object of preposition
3. Making new friends is sometimes difficult.	No gerund	Has a gerund ☐ Subject ☐ Object ☐ Object of preposition
4. Copying other people’s words and claiming them as your own is wrong.	No gerund	Has a gerund ☐ Subject ☐ Object ☐ Object of preposition
5. I never dreamed of coming to the United States. Then I got married, and I had to come.	No gerund	Has a gerund ☐ Subject ☐ Object ☐ Object of preposition
6. My oldest daughter was born while I was living in Texas.	No gerund	Has a gerund ☐ Subject ☐ Object ☐ Object of preposition

✓ Practice 2C

Write sentences about these gerunds and gerund phrases. Use the gerund as a subject, or use one of the following verbs that take gerund objects: *enjoy, like, dislike, am interested in*. Be prepared to share your sentences.

Example: (reading) Reading is fun for me. OR I enjoy reading novels.

1. (reading)

2. (playing soccer)
3. (listening to music)
4. (smoking)
5. (driving in the snow)
6. (washing dishes)

✓ Practice 3C

Write a short paragraph (4-6 sentences) about your opinion of one of these topics. Your paragraph should have a topic sentence that states your opinion.

- renting an apartment - eating fast food
- owning a pet - living in a big city

Sentences with gerund subjects that have a *be* verb can also be expressed with a *to* + V form (infinitive) in the same way as a gerund subject. However, these sentences usually begin with *It*.

Watching sports is fun for me. (gerund as Subject)

It is fun for me to watch sports.

The *It* is not pointing to any particular noun, so it is called a “non-referential *It*” or “dummy *It*.”

✓ Practice 4C

Change the sentences from having a gerund as Subject to *It* + infinitive.

(Example) Watching TV is relaxing for me. *It is relaxing for me to watch TV.*

1. Learning English is difficult for me.
2. Reading to children is important.
3. Making rice is easy.
4. Driving without a license is illegal.
5. Traveling alone is a little scary for Jill.

This page titled [2.3: Appendix C- Gerund Subjects and Non-referential \(“dummy”\) It](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Heather Zettelmaier](#) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

2.4: Appendix D- Plural Agreement and Basic Article Use

Errors in **subject/verb agreement** and **plural agreement** are affected by the kind of noun that you are using. The three kinds of nouns in English are:

1. Count – Singular Examples:
2. Count – Plural Examples:
3. Noncount Examples:

When you write about a topic in general, for example, about “teenagers”, “people” or “sports,” *count* nouns will need a plural “s.” When you are using a singular or noncount noun, there is no “s” on the noun, but the verb will need to agree with a singular subject, thus requiring “s.”

✓ Practice D1

Errors in **subject/verb agreement** and **plural agreement** are affected by the kind of noun that you are using. The three kinds of nouns in English are:

1. Count – Singular Examples:
2. Count – Plural Examples:
3. Noncount Examples:

When you write about a topic in general, for example, about “teenagers”, “people” or “sports,” *count* nouns will need a plural “s.” When you are using a singular or noncount noun, there is no “s” on the noun, but the verb will need to agree with a singular subject, thus requiring “s.”

To use **articles** (a, an, the, and Ø) in English correctly, first ask yourself, “What kind of noun is it?” Then ask yourself, “Which article do I need?”

Types of Nouns (review):	Examples (review):	Indefinite Article:	Definite Article:
1.		a / an	the
2.		Ø	the
3.		Ø	the

✓ Practice D2

Write a, an, the or Ø in the spaces.

1. I have ____ big family. My mother shows ____ love to all of us. ____ first time my husband met my family, he was impressed with ____ love that my mother showed everyone.
2. I’m so busy. I rarely have ____ time to do ____ homework. If I have ____ chance, I will study tonight.
3. I talked to ____ interesting person on ____ bus. She gave me ____ good advice about ____ money.
4. Is that ____ good book? Yes, but it’s too hard for me. Maybe I should ____ study literature next year.
5. ____ Friendships can help you learn ____ language. Talking with ____ friend over ____ cup of ____ coffee can help you learn ____ vocabulary.
6. Mogadishu is ____ capital of my country.

This page titled [2.4: Appendix D- Plural Agreement and Basic Article Use](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Heather Zettelaier](#) via [source content](#) that was edited to the style and standards of the LibreTexts platform.

Index

A

academic skills

[2: Summary Writing](#)

academic writing

[3: The Basics of Paragraphs](#)

accessible learning

[InfoPage](#)

adaptive learning

[InfoPage](#)

adjectives

[1: Sentences](#)

adverbs

[1: Sentences](#)

agreement

[2: Appendix](#)

American education

[6: Supporting Opinions with Reasons](#)

appendix

[2: Appendix](#)

article

[2: Appendix](#)

articles

[2.4: Appendix D- Plural Agreement and Basic Article Use](#)

B

biographies

[5: Narrative Writing- Using the Simple Past](#)

C

capitalization

[Peer Reviews](#)

college assignments

[2: Summary Writing](#)

college writing

[6: Supporting Opinions with Reasons](#)

communication skills

[6: Supporting Opinions with Reasons](#)

concise writing

[2: Summary Writing](#)

conclusion sentence

[3: The Basics of Paragraphs](#)

cooking

[4: Routines and Opinions- Using the Simple Present](#)

corrections

[2.2: Appendix B- Personal Spelling List and Practice](#)

count_nouns

[2.4: Appendix D- Plural Agreement and Basic Article Use](#)

course materials

[InfoPage](#)

cultural practices

[5: Narrative Writing- Using the Simple Past](#)

D

definite_article

[2.4: Appendix D- Plural Agreement and Basic Article Use](#)

details

[6: Supporting Opinions with Reasons](#)

E

education

[2.1: Appendix A- List of Frequently Misspelled Words](#)

effective writing

[3: The Basics of Paragraphs](#)

emotional experiences

[5: Narrative Writing- Using the Simple Past](#)

English

[2.3: Appendix C- Gerund Subjects and Non-referential \(“dummy”\) It](#)

English grammar

[5: Narrative Writing- Using the Simple Past](#)

English_grammar

[2.4: Appendix D- Plural Agreement and Basic Article Use](#)

English_language_learning

[4: Routines and Opinions- Using the Simple Present](#)

ESL writing

[3: The Basics of Paragraphs](#)

F

facts

[6: Supporting Opinions with Reasons](#)

frequently

[2: Appendix](#)

G

gerund

[2: Appendix](#)

[2.3: Appendix C- Gerund Subjects and Non-referential \(“dummy”\) It](#)

grammar

[1: Sentences](#)

[2.1: Appendix A- List of Frequently Misspelled Words](#)

[2.3: Appendix C- Gerund Subjects and Non-referential \(“dummy”\) It](#)

[Peer Reviews](#)

H

higher education

[InfoPage](#)

historical events

[5: Narrative Writing- Using the Simple Past](#)

homework

[2.1: Appendix A- List of Frequently Misspelled Words](#)

I

indefinite_article

[2.4: Appendix D- Plural Agreement and Basic Article Use](#)

information organization

[3: The Basics of Paragraphs](#)

interactive textbooks

[InfoPage](#)

irregular_verbs

[4: Routines and Opinions- Using the Simple Present](#)

L

language

[1: Sentences](#)

[2.1: Appendix A- List of Frequently Misspelled Words](#)

learning

[2.1: Appendix A- List of Frequently Misspelled Words](#)

lessons learned

[5: Narrative Writing- Using the Simple Past](#)

LibreTexts

[InfoPage](#)

M

memory tricks

[2.2: Appendix B- Personal Spelling List and Practice](#)

misspelled

[2: Appendix](#)

N

narrative paragraph

[Peer Reviews](#)

narrative writing

[5: Narrative Writing- Using the Simple Past](#)

negative_forms

[4: Routines and Opinions- Using the Simple Present](#)

noncount_nouns

[2.4: Appendix D- Plural Agreement and Basic Article Use](#)

noun

[2.3: Appendix C- Gerund Subjects and Non-referential \(“dummy”\) It](#)

nouns

[1: Sentences](#)

[2.4: Appendix D- Plural Agreement and Basic Article Use](#)

O

object

[2.3: Appendix C- Gerund Subjects and Non-referential \(“dummy”\) It](#)

objective writing

[2: Summary Writing](#)

OER

[InfoPage](#)

open education

[InfoPage](#)

opinion

[6: Supporting Opinions with Reasons](#)

opinion paragraph

[Peer Reviews](#)

oral summaries

[2: Summary Writing](#)

P

paragraph organization

[Peer Reviews](#)

paragraph structure

[3: The Basics of Paragraphs](#)

past experiences

[5: Narrative Writing- Using the Simple Past](#)

peer review

[Peer Reviews](#)

plagiarism

[2: Summary Writing](#)

plural

[2: Appendix](#)

plural_agreement

[2.4: Appendix D- Plural Agreement and Basic Article Use](#)

plural_nouns

[4: Routines and Opinions- Using the Simple Present](#)

practice

[2: Appendix](#)

[2.2: Appendix B- Personal Spelling List and Practice](#)

practice_exercises

[4: Routines and Opinions- Using the Simple Present](#)

preposition

[2.3: Appendix C- Gerund Subjects and Non-referential \(“dummy”\) It](#)

pronouns

[1: Sentences](#)

punctuation

[Peer Reviews](#)

R

reading comprehension

[2: Summary Writing](#)

routines

[4: Routines and Opinions- Using the Simple Present](#)

S

sentence

[2.3: Appendix C- Gerund Subjects and Non-referential \(“dummy”\) It](#)

sentence structure

[Peer Reviews](#)

sentences

[1: Sentences](#)

simple_present_tense

[4: Routines and Opinions- Using the Simple Present](#)

singular_nouns

[2.4: Appendix D- Plural Agreement and Basic Article Use](#)

skills

[2.1: Appendix A- List of Frequently Misspelled Words](#)

spelling

[2: Appendix](#)

[2.1: Appendix A- List of Frequently Misspelled Words](#)

[2.2: Appendix B- Personal Spelling List and Practice](#)

storytelling

[5: Narrative Writing- Using the Simple Past](#)

subject

[2.3: Appendix C- Gerund Subjects and Non-referential \(“dummy”\) It](#)

subject_verb_agreement

[2.4: Appendix D- Plural Agreement and Basic Article Use](#)

subjects

[2: Appendix](#)

summary

[Peer Reviews](#)

summary writing

[2: Summary Writing](#)

support

[6: Supporting Opinions with Reasons](#)

supporting sentences

[3: The Basics of Paragraphs](#)

syntax

[2.3: Appendix C- Gerund Subjects and Non-referential \(“dummy”\) It](#)

T

technology

[2.1: Appendix A- List of Frequently Misspelled Words](#)

textbooks

[InfoPage](#)

the_weekend_cook

[4: Routines and Opinions- Using the Simple Present](#)

tips for writing

[2: Summary Writing](#)

topic sentence

[3: The Basics of Paragraphs](#)

transitions

[6: Supporting Opinions with Reasons](#)

V

verbs

[1: Sentences](#)

[4: Routines and Opinions- Using the Simple Present](#)

vocabulary

[1: Sentences](#)

W

women's rights

[5: Narrative Writing- Using the Simple Past](#)

words

[2.1: Appendix A- List of Frequently Misspelled Words](#)

writing

[1: Sentences](#)

[6: Supporting Opinions with Reasons](#)

[2.1: Appendix A- List of Frequently Misspelled Words](#)

[2.2: Appendix B- Personal Spelling List and Practice](#)

[2.3: Appendix C- Gerund Subjects and Non-referential \(“dummy”\) It](#)

writing skills

[2: Summary Writing](#)

[3: The Basics of Paragraphs](#)

[6: Supporting Opinions with Reasons](#)

[Peer Reviews](#)

writing tips

[3: The Basics of Paragraphs](#)

Glossary

Sample Word 1 | Sample Definition 1

SECTION OVERVIEW

Peer Reviews

Unit 2 Peer Review: Summary

Writer's name: Your name:

How many sentences are in this summary?

Check (✓) the following:

___ The writer used his or her own words, not the original text.

___ The writer included only the main ideas of the text.

___ The writer did not include his or her opinion.

Read the summary again. Look for problems in these areas: Paragraph format

Capital letters and periods (complete sentences) Verb tenses (simple present for summaries of stories) Use of commas and periods (sentence boundaries)

Unit 3 Peer Review: Paragraph with Listing Order

Writer's name: Your name:

1. In three or four words, what is the topic of the paragraph? (What did the writer write about?)
2. How many sentences are in this paragraph?
3. Does each sentence begin with a capital letter? Yes No
 - o Does each sentence end with a period? Yes No

If "No," help the writer fix their sentences. Circle the capital letters and periods that you add.

4. Do you see an error in any of the sentences? If so, write one of the sentences here, but correct the error
5. Was this paragraph interesting to you? Yes No Why or why not? Explain.

Unit 4 Peer Review: Opinion Paragraph with Simple Present

Writer's name: _____ Your name: _____

1. In three or four words, what is the topic of the paragraph? (What did the writer write about?) _____ Did the writer begin with a **topic sentence** that includes the topic + a feeling or opinion? _____ Yes _____ No
2. How many sentences are in this paragraph? _____
3. Does each sentence begin with a capital letter? _____ Yes _____ No Does each sentence end with a period? _____ Yes _____ No If "No," help the writer fix their sentences. Circle the capital letters and periods that you add.
4. Look at the *NOUNS* in this paragraph. Are there nouns that need a **plural "s"**? Add the plural "s" where necessary. Are there nouns that need the article **a, an, or the**? Are there nouns that need the article removed (the zero Ø article?)
5. Look at the *VERBS* in this paragraph. Did the writer form the simple present verb tense correctly?
6. Was this paragraph interesting to you? _____ Yes _____ No Why or why not? Explain.

Unit 5 Peer Review: Narrative Paragraph with Simple Past

Writer's Name: _____ Your name: _____

1. Look at the first sentence of this paragraph. Which topic did this writer choose? Circle one: a topic from Practice 5E, My Best Day, A Time when I was Afraid. From the topic sentence, what is the writer's opinion/feeling about the topic?
2. Does each sentence begin with a capital letter? _____ Yes _____ No

Does each sentence end with a period? _____ Yes _____ No

If “No,” help the writer fix their sentences. Ask if you are not sure.

3. Does this writer use “and,” “but,” or “so” correctly? (with commas) _____ Yes _____ No. If “No,” help the writer use these words correctly.

4. Look at the *VERBS* in this paragraph. Did the writer form the simple past verb tense correctly? _____ Yes _____ No

Underline all of the simple past verbs in this paragraph.

5. Was this paragraph interesting to you? _____ Yes _____ No _____ Why or _____ why not? Explain.

Unit 6: Peer Review: Paragraph about Reasons

Writer’s Name: _____ Peer Editor: _____

1. Look at the topic sentence of the paragraph. Is it clear from the topic sentence that the paragraph will be a list of reasons? _____ Yes _____ No

2. Read the paragraph. How many reasons did the writer use to answer the question? What were the reasons?

Reason 1:

Reason 2:

Reason 3: Can you think of any other reasons about this topic? Another reason:

3. How many sentences are in this paragraph?

4. Did the writer use “signal words” like *First*, *Second*, and *Finally*? Circle  the signal words.

5. Look at the verbs in the paragraph. Did the writer use simple present and simple past correctly? Check these other areas for errors: Run-on sentences, Punctuation, Fragments, Agreement (plural “s”), Capital letters, Articles

6. Did you agree with the writer? Why or why not?

Units 3, 4, 5, or 6 Self-Check: Edit Your Own Paragraph

Name:

Answer these questions about your paragraph.

1. Do you have a topic sentence? _____ Yes _____ No. If yes, then underline your topic sentence. What is your paragraph about?

2. How many sentences are in your paragraph? Check to see if every sentence begins with a capital letter and ends with a period. Make changes with a red pen.

3. Did you indent the paragraph? _____ Yes _____ No. If “No”, then put an arrow → at the beginning of your paragraph.

4. Write a title at the top of the page. Follow the rules for titles from *Low Intermediate Writing OER*.

5. Read your paragraph out loud. Try to find two or three more mistakes and correct them. Ask your teacher if you are not sure.

Detailed Licensing

Overview

Title: [Low Intermediate ESL Writing \(ESL 130\)](#)

Webpages: 23

Applicable Restrictions: Noncommercial

All licenses found:

- [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#): 87% (20 pages)
- [Undeclared](#): 13% (3 pages)

By Page

- [Low Intermediate ESL Writing \(ESL 130\)](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Front Matter](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [TitlePage](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [InfoPage](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Table of Contents](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [Licensing](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [1: Chapters](#) - [Undeclared](#)
 - [1: Sentences](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [2: Summary Writing](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [3: The Basics of Paragraphs](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [4: Routines and Opinions- Using the Simple Present](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [5: Narrative Writing- Using the Simple Past](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [6: Supporting Opinions with Reasons](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
- [2: Appendix](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [2.1: Appendix A- List of Frequently Misspelled Words](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [2.2: Appendix B- Personal Spelling List and Practice](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [2.3: Appendix C- Gerund Subjects and Non-referential \(“dummy”\) It](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [2.4: Appendix D- Plural Agreement and Basic Article Use](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
- [Back Matter](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Index](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Glossary](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Peer Reviews](#) - [CC BY-NC-SA 4.0](#)
 - [Detailed Licensing](#) - [Undeclared](#)